

experience on the network is qualitatively seamless and hassle-free.

ONDC is enabling decentralised value assimilation and integration such that specialised goods and services offerings can create transactional engagements with each other for the benefit of the entire ecosystem. For instance, a merchant who is a producer of specialised goods can benefit from e-commerce without worrying about marketing and logistics services. It is removing switching costs for consumers between platforms, ensuring the enhancement of the online experience, and leading to the end of the era of gatekeepers in e-commerce.

ONDC's alpha pilot to a closed user group launched in April 2022 and has now extended to 80-plus cities. It launched beta testing in Bengaluru, in end-September, with 22 network participants, 12 seller-applications, seven buyer applications and three

logistics applications. And 300-plus further entities are under various stages of integration as seller/buyer/logistics app, which includes large entities like HUL and IDFC bank, and start-ups like Meesho and Ninjacart. Entities like the Ministry of MSME and SIDBI are helping create market access through ONDC for their constituents, including micro enterprises and retailers. NABARD and SFAC are working on a programme to bring the agriculture sector to ONDC, such that farmer producer organisations (FPOs) are able to leverage this invaluable technology to assist farmers find the right prices for their produce. The One District One Product (ODOP) programme is already live on the ONDC network, and ONDC has initiated outreach programmes to commence integration efforts for other similar initiatives across India.

The beta test is open to the public in urban Bengaluru in grocery

and food & beverages. It provides a valuable opportunity to review and solve any operational or technical challenge, bolster the confidence of on-boarded and incoming network participants and showcase the technological marvel that ONDC proposes. In the coming months, ONDC will be adding other domains such as fashion, BPC, home decor, electronics, etc., providing equal opportunities to big and small organisations to usher in a new era in e-commerce formulated and implemented in India.

These trends are naturally intensifying with ONDC structured as an opportunity plank for entrepreneurs and start-ups to think anew and reach the hinterland of the nation. As a result, it is not hard to foresee that going forward, instead of having a few companies dominate the market sphere, there will be a Cambrian explosion of start-ups leveraging the network, thereby benefitting the entire e-commerce sector.

India's techade is focussed on technological innovations and empowering the marginalised with its open, inclusive, interoperable, transparent and trust-based design principles. We are at a pivotal moment in our developmental trajectory. As technology shapes ideas, individuals and institutions, there is an opportunity to design a technological architecture for India and for the world, with an active push for a fair and just society.

ONDC is playing its part in this techade by unleashing economic freedom for every unique merchant and consumer. It is building a new model for the world in e-commerce, empowering every individual and entity with an opportunity to realise their potential in the Indian economy and beyond. **BT**

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ILLUSTRATION BY RAJ VERMA

